

INVENTION

JULIAN CALENDAR

Based on a lunar calendar, the Roman year was only 355 days long, and was adjusted by occasional extra months. Caesar introduced a 12-month year of 365 days, with a 366-day leap year once every four years. To align Rome with the solar cycle, 46 BCE was made into a 445-day year. The Julian calendar then came into force in 45 BCE. It was in general use in Europe until the Gregorian calendar was introduced in 1582, and is still used by the Greek Orthodox Church.



**"I came, I saw,
I conquered."**

JULIUS CAESAR AFTER BATTLE OF ZELA

command in the Roman provinces of Gaul. There he showed outstanding energy and ruthlessness in years of campaigning against the Celtic and Germanic tribes of the region. Caesar went beyond the borders of his provincial command, making forays across the Rhine in Germany and north as far as the Thames River in Britain. Victories brought him both wealth and renown.

They also gave him an instrument for attaining power: he shared the hardships and dangers of his legions on the march and in battle, praised and rewarded them, and in return they were loyal to him rather than to the Republic.

Rome's civil war

In late 50 BCE the Senate, under the control of Pompey, the distinguished military leader, called on Caesar to disband his army after his ten-year command in Gaul had come to a successful conclusion. Instead, Caesar



led his legions across the Rubicon, the stream separating Cisalpine Gaul (the region to the south of the Alps) from Italy proper. Easily occupying Rome, he took on Pompey in an armed struggle for control of the Roman world. After two years of fighting, the battle of Pharsalus in August 48 proved decisive for Caesar.

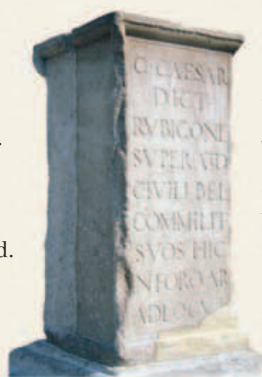
Pompey escaped from the scene of his defeat, only to be murdered a month later in Egypt. Although Pompey's sons, Sextus and Gnaeus, continued the civil war until 45 BCE, Caesar's outstanding military skills had won him the supreme power he sought.

Reform and power

During his brief reign, Caesar revealed a zeal for innovation and reform. He halved the number of Roman citizens dependent on handouts of bread from the state by resettling the destitute in colonies in Italy and abroad, and reformed the calendar, see above. Yet he also exhibited great arrogance. For example, the Republic had in the past appointed a temporary "dictator," a leader with exceptional power

Caesar's death

Brutus steps forward to stab Caesar in this painting by 19th-century artist Vincenzo Camuccini. According to Latin author Suetonius, Caesar said: "You too, my child?," indicating that Brutus may have been his son.



Caesar's column

This column marks the place outside Rimini, Italy, where Caesar crossed the Rubicon in 49 BCE.

The heart of the republic

The Forum, the heart of Rome, is where Caesar's supporter, Mark Antony, delivered a funeral oration over his body after the assassination. A temple to Caesar was later erected on the spot where he was cremated.

to cope with an emergency, but Caesar permanently assumed the role, and advertised the fact on coins.

Brutal assassination

In March 44 Caesar planned to lead an army on a campaign against the Parthians in the Middle East. A group of senators led by Gaius Cassius Longinus and Marcus Junius Brutus, inspired by an idealistic attachment to the Republic, and the desire to defend their own privileges, conspired to kill him before he left Rome. They stabbed him in the assembly hall, where he had come to address the Senate. Ironically, his death brought about the end of the Republic his assassins were trying to restore, and two years after his death, the Senate made him a deity. He is remembered today as a skilled orator, author, and military leader.



TIMELINE

- **July 12 or 13, 100 BCE** Gaius Julius Caesar is born into a patrician family in Rome.
- **87** Caesar's uncle by marriage, the famous general Gaius Marius, seizes power in Rome.
- **83** Caesar marries Cornelia, the daughter of powerful patrician, Cinna; he becomes high priest of Jupiter.
- **81** Sulla, the enemy of Marius and Cinna, becomes dictator of Rome; dismissed from his priesthood, Caesar is forced into hiding.
- **80** Caesar takes refuge in Bithynia in Asia Minor, where it is alleged he becomes the lover of the Bithynian king, Nicomedes IV.
- **78** After Sulla's death, Caesar returns to Rome.
- **75** Kidnapped by pirates on a voyage to Rhodes, Caesar is ransomed. He then catches and crucifies his kidnappers.
- **69** After the death of his first wife, Caesar marries Pompeia, granddaughter of Sulla.
- **65** Appointed *curule aedile* (a public office of the Republic responsible for, among other things, the regulation of public festivals), Caesar courts popularity by organizing lavish festivities.
- **63** Caesar is elected *pontifex maximus*, chief priest of the Roman state religion; Cicero, the statesman, accuses him of involvement in the Catiline conspiracy, led by the Roman politician Catullus, and aiming to take over the republic.
- **62** Caesar divorces Pompeia.
- **60** Returning from a spell as governor of Further Spain, Caesar makes a deal to share power in Rome with Pompey and Crassus, forming the First Triumvirate.
- **59** Caesar's daughter Julia marries Pompey; he marries his third wife, Calpurnia. He is granted a five-year governorship of Cisalpine Gaul and Illyricum (in modern Albania); Transalpine Gaul is soon added to his command.
- **58** Caesar begins his conquest of Gaul by defeating the Helvetii tribesmen and Germanic king Ariovistus.
- **55–54** Caesar twice invades Britain and twice bridges the Rhine; his command in Gaul is extended for another five years.
- **January 10, 49** Defying a call from the Senate to disband his army at the end of his governorship, Caesar crosses the Rubicon (Fiumicino) into Italy, precipitating civil war.
- **June 23, 47** The Ptolemaic Queen, Cleopatra, gives birth to Caesarion, probably Caesar's son.
- **August 47** Caesar defeats Pharnaces, king of Pontus and the Bosphorus, at the battle of Zela.
- **March 45** Caesar defeats the last of Pompey's army at Munda in Spain, ending the civil war.
- **February 15, 44** Appointed dictator for life.
- **March 15, 44** Caesar assassinated by a group of conspirators set on restoring the Republic.



COIN SHOWING CAESAR